influence and change how the Chinese political elite looked at China's achievements and its position in international affairs.[89] Even though it took until 2017 before Xi Jin-ping declared the arrival of a "new era" for China, the first signs of new thinking and new policies in Beijing had by then been visible for some time already.

Within a few days after being voted in as China's new leader in 2012, Xi Jin-ping put forward the "China Dream" as his political slogan, promising welfare to his people and working towards rejuvenating China's position as a great power.[90] Furthermore, during his first visit to the United States as Head of State half a year later, Xi suggested "a new type of Great Power relations" in Sino–US relations, signalling an expectation that China now wanted to be treated as an equal to the United States.[91] Later the same year, Xi launched China's new Silk Road Diplomacy, later named the Belt and Road Initiative (BRI). At the next Party Congress in 2017, through his policy doctrine "Xi Jinping's thought on socialism with Chinese characteristics for the new age" written into the Communist Party constitution, Xi in reality put the official stamp on the more assertive turn in Chinese foreign policy that had been underway for some time already.[92] China has risen, and a new strategy has to be crafted – not one tailored to the multi-polar world China had been promoting since the 1990s but one that fit the new Sino–US bipolar system in world politics.[93]

Xi Jinping's China is confirming the assumption that "a change in a state's power and wealth usually causes a corresponding change in the foreign policy of the state,"[94] and rich and powerful states have greater ambitions, including in their security policy, than small and weaker states. Economic growth is still fundamentally important for China, but it now shows fewer reservations about flexing its military muscles and finds it less important to adhere to Deng Xiaoping's mantra of "keeping a low profile." Power